

“ TO THE STRONGEST! ”

Alexander the Great, on his deathbed in reply to a question about who would succeed him

ALEXANDER THE GREAT had not provided for an orderly succession after his death in 323 BCE, and his most experienced generals were also dead—except for Antipater, who had been left as regent in Macedonia. Alexander's wife Roxane was pregnant, and he had a half-brother Arrhidaeus, who was, unfortunately, mentally unstable. **A clique of generals** who were present at Alexander's deathbed—

Ptolemy, Cassander, Seleucus, and Lysimachus—engineered a solution by which Roxane's newborn son Alexander IV (323–310 BCE) notionally shared power with Arrhidaeus, who became **Philip III**. In reality, this military clique carved up the empire between themselves and four other generals. **Perdiccas** emerged as the main power in the center; **Antipater** and **Craterus** took Europe; **Antigonos Monophthalmus** (“the one-eyed”) was given Phrygia; **Ptolemy** got Egypt; and **Seleucus** and **Cassander** were promoted to senior military commands.

These generals, who became known as the **Diadochoi** (“successors”), then fought a long series of wars for dominance in Alexander's former empire, at first pitting the others against Perdiccas, who was assassinated in 320 BCE. Antipater rose to power next, but he died of natural causes in 318 BCE, leaving Antigonos to make a bid for power

80,000

ANTIGONUS

75,000

LYSIMACHUS

Battle of Ipsus

Although slightly outnumbered, Lysimachus deployed his archers against his enemy's flank, causing Antigonos's infantry to flee in panic.

against the four remaining principal players: Cassander in Macedonia, Ptolemy in Egypt, Lysimachus in Thrace, and Seleucus in Babylon. War between the parties raged inconclusively until 311 BCE. But when it was renewed again in 308 BCE, it looked as if Antigonos might overcome all the others. Then, in 301 BCE, **Lysimachus crushed the Antigonid army** at Ipsus, and annexed most of Antigonos's former territories, so cementing a **tripartite division** of Alexander's empire between himself, Ptolemy, and Seleucus.

In India, in around 320 BCE, **Chandragupta Maurya** (r. c. 320–297 BCE) overthrew the last of the Nandas (see 370–356 BCE) to become ruler of Magadha and the Ganges plain. An energetic ruler, he then gradually absorbed the

outlying regions of the Nanda Empire, pushing his control as far as Gujarat and the Punjab. In 305 BCE, he began a campaign against one of Alexander's successors, **Seleucus**, which ended in a treaty in 303 BCE, under which the Greeks ceded control of eastern Afghanistan and Baluchistan to Chandragupta. Having established the **Mauryan Empire** in 307 BCE, Chandragupta decided to abdicate in favor of his son **Bindusara** (r. 297–272 BCE). He then retired to become a Jain monk, ultimately starving himself to death.

In China, **Meng Zi** (or Mencius) (c. 372–289 BCE) arrived at the Wei court around 320 BCE and rapidly earned himself a reputation as the “second sage” of the

Confucian tradition. His surviving work, the ***Shi Ji***, is written in the form of dialogues with several contemporary kings. Meng Zi stresses the value of *de* (virtue) for a king and, more practically, recommends lower taxes, less harsh punishments, and ensuring that the people have enough to eat. He believed that if a king acted benevolently, everyone would want to be ruled by him, and he would have no need of conquest. Meng Zi's benevolent view of human nature had a widespread appeal, and politically his views were most influential in the time of the **Song dynasty** (960–1279 CE).



Samnite-style helmet

The Romans admired the Samnites as fighters. This gladiator helmet is based on the Samnite style of armor.



ALEXANDER THE GREAT (356–323 BCE)

At age 20, Alexander inherited much of Greece from his father; by his death just 13 years later, he had extended this to cover a vast area from the Indus River in the east to Illyria in the west. He was a brilliant general but prone to acts of impetuous violence. His adoption of Persian court ritual alienated many native Macedonians, and his not naming an heir proved catastrophic.

323 BCE Outbreak of the Lamian (or Hellespontic) War between Athens and her allies and the Macedonians in Thessaly

321 BCE Athens defeated by Antipater; peace terms entail the end of Athenian democracy

312 BCE Rome's first aqueduct built by Appius Claudius

310 BCE Alexander IV, son of Alexander the Great, dies

307 BCE Athens falls under Macedonian control

305 BCE Seleucus establishes himself in Persia and Anatolia, founding the Seleucid Dynasty

304 BCE Second Samnite War ends; Rome wins but gains no territory

302 BCE Chandragupta Maurya signs a peace treaty with Seleucus

301 BCE At the Battle of Ipsus, Lysimachus and Seleucus defeat Antigonos, who is killed